

Four Main Types of Synthesis

1. Explanatory Synthesis

Explaining a topic clearly using multiple sources without taking a strong position.

Structure:

- Introduce the topic
- Use information from different sources to explain
- Stay neutral (no opinion or argument)

Example (Topic: *Social Media and Mental Health*):

Social media use has become a regular part of daily life, especially for young people. Brown (2021) explains that these platforms often show idealized versions of people's lives, which may create unrealistic comparisons. Similarly, Ahmed and Lee (2020) observed that high usage can be linked to feelings of loneliness and anxiety. On the other hand, Williams (2019) highlights how social media can support users by providing online spaces for emotional expression and peer connection. These studies show that social media has both positive and negative effects on mental health depending on how it is used.

2. Argumentative Synthesis

Developing and Supporting your own opinion or argument using information from sources.

Structure:

- State your argument (thesis)
- Use sources to support or oppose the argument
- Conclude strongly

Example:

Although social media is often blamed for mental health issues, it should not be viewed as harmful by default. While Brown (2021) and Ahmed and Lee (2020) emphasize the risks of overuse and self-comparison, these issues arise more from how individuals engage with social media, not from the platforms themselves. Williams (2019) provides strong evidence that when used intentionally—for support groups or self-expression—social media can improve emotional well-being. Therefore, the key issue is not whether social media is harmful, but whether users are equipped with the awareness and digital literacy to use it in healthy ways.

3. Comparative Synthesis

Comparing and contrasting sources (similarities and/or differences).

Structure:

- Introduce the sources or ideas being compared
- Point out similarities and differences
- Show what we learn from the comparison

Example:

Brown (2021) and Ahmed and Lee (2020) both describe how social media can negatively impact mental health by encouraging users to compare themselves with idealized online images. However, Williams (2019) presents a different view, focusing on the positive uses of social media, such as joining support groups and sharing personal experiences. While Brown and Ahmed and Lee highlight risks, Williams emphasizes potential benefits, suggesting that the effects of social media depend greatly on the user's purpose and mindset.

4. Thematic Synthesis

Organizing ideas around key themes rather than summarizing source by source.

Structure:

- Identify 2–3 key themes from the topic
- Group ideas from different sources under each theme
- Discuss how the themes help us understand the issue

Example:

Two main themes emerge when discussing social media and mental health: emotional impact and user behavior. On the emotional side, Brown (2021) and Ahmed and Lee (2020) note that users often feel anxious or isolated after comparing their lives to others online. In contrast, when looking at user behavior, Williams (2019) stresses that those who engage actively and positively—such as joining support communities—may actually benefit from the experience. This suggests that the emotional outcomes of social media are closely tied to the ways in which individuals choose to engage with it.